Brücke

Getting started: a complete beginner's guide

From installing Python to your first German lesson. No programming experience needed.

WINDOWS EDITION

Who this guide is for

Anyone who wants to use **Brücke**, a personal German and French trainer that takes you from beginner (A1) to intermediate (B1) in 26 weeks, and has **never written code or used a command line**. Every step says exactly what to click and what to type, and shows what you should see afterwards.

What you need

- A **Windows 10 or 11** computer. On a MacBook? Use the **Mac edition** of this guide instead.
- An **internet connection** for the one-time setup. After that, Brücke works offline.
- **Google Chrome** or **Microsoft Edge**. They have the best German and French voices.
- A **microphone** (optional) for the speaking exercises. A laptop's built-in one is fine.
- About **30 minutes**. You only do the setup once.

What's inside

Part 1	**Setting up** (once)	Steps 1–6: install Python, download Brücke, start it
Part 2	**Every day**	Starting and stopping Brücke, plus a one-click starter
Part 3	**Using Brücke**	A tour of the screens, the colour code and the shortcuts
Part 4	**Extras and help**	AI writing feedback, backups, updates, fixing problems

BEFORE YOU START

A few words you'll meet

You don't need to understand how any of this works inside. These are the only terms the guide uses:

Word	What it means here
Python	A free program that runs other programs. Brücke is written in Python, so your computer needs it first.
PowerShell (the "terminal")	A window where you *type* instructions instead of clicking. It looks old-fashioned and plain. That's normal.
Command	One line of text you type into PowerShell, then press **Enter** to run it.
Folder	The same folders you already know from File Explorer, such as Documents or Downloads.
Package	A ready-made building block that Brücke needs, downloaded from the internet in Step 5.
Toolbox (virtual environment)	A private folder called **.venv** that holds Python and Brücke's packages, kept separate from everything else on your computer.
localhost	"This computer." Brücke runs on your own machine and you open it in your browser like a website, but nothing goes online.

How to read the boxes in this guide

TYPE THIS, THEN PRESS ENTER

```
python --version
```

A dark box like the one above is a **command**. Type it into PowerShell **exactly** as shown, with the same spaces, dots and slashes, then press **Enter**. Capital letters don't matter on Windows, but spaces do.

WHAT YOU SHOULD SEE

```
Python 3.15.1
```

A grey box like this one shows what PowerShell should print back. Your numbers may differ slightly.

> **Copy and paste works**
>
> You can copy a command from this PDF and paste it into PowerShell. Paste by **right-clicking** inside the PowerShell window, or with **Ctrl+V**. Then press Enter.

PART 1 · SETTING UP (ONCE)

Six steps to your first lesson

Do these in order. Each one only takes a few minutes, and you will never have to repeat most of them.

1 Install Python

Free, from the official website. About 5 minutes.

1. Open your browser and go to **python.org/downloads**.
2. Click the big yellow **Download** button near the top. Windows may call this the **"Python install manager"**. That's the right one.
3. Open the file you downloaded (it's usually in your **Downloads** folder) and follow the installer. If you see a box saying **"Add python.exe to PATH"**, **tick it** before you click Install.

Now check that it worked. Open **PowerShell**: click the **Start** button, type **powershell**, and press Enter. A dark window opens. Type:

TYPE THIS, THEN PRESS ENTER

```
python --version
```

WHAT YOU SHOULD SEE

```
Python 3.15.1
```

If Python asks you some setup questions

The first time you run **python**, Windows' Python install manager may ask a few questions, such as whether to add a folder to your *PATH* or to install the latest Python. Type **y** and press Enter for each one. If Windows asks for permission, click **Yes**. When it's finished, **close PowerShell and open it again**, then run **python --version** once more.

Seeing "python is not recognized" or the Microsoft Store?

Close every PowerShell window and open a new one. PowerShell only notices new programs when it starts. If it still fails, try typing **py --version** instead. If that works, type **py** wherever this guide says **python**. Otherwise run the installer again and make sure the PATH box is ticked.

2 Download Brücke

From GitHub, a website where programmers share code. No account needed.

1. Go to **github.com/oladapo-joseph/brucke**.
2. Click the green **<> Code** button, then **Download ZIP** at the bottom of the menu that opens.
3. Open your **Downloads** folder, **right-click** the file **brucke-main.zip** and choose **Extract All...**, then click **Extract**.
4. Move the extracted **brucke-main** folder somewhere permanent, such as **Documents**. You can rename it to **Brucke** if you like. Do this now, *before* Step 4.

Open the folder. You are in the right place when you can see these items:

Inside the Brücke folder	
app · **static** · **docs** · **tests**	folders
requirements.txt · **README.md** · **run.sh**	files

The "folder inside a folder" trap

Windows often extracts to **brucke-main\brucke-main**. If you open **brucke-main** and only see *another* brucke-main folder, open that inner one. The right folder is the one that contains **requirements.txt**. Also make sure you're not looking *inside the .zip file*: always extract first.

3 Open PowerShell in the Brücke folder

So the commands you type act on Brücke's files.

1. In File Explorer, open the Brücke folder (the one with **requirements.txt** in it).
2. Click once on the **address bar** at the top of the window (where the folder path is shown). The text turns blue.
3. Type **powershell** over it and press **Enter**.

A PowerShell window opens, already "standing" in that folder. The line it shows before your cursor ends with the folder's location, for example:

```
THE PROMPT SHOULD END WITH YOUR FOLDER
PS C:\Users\Ada\Documents\Brucke>
```

Another way

In Windows 11 you can also **right-click an empty area** inside the folder and choose **Open in Terminal**.

4 Create Brücke's private toolbox

One command. It makes a folder called .venv.

This gives Brücke its own private copy of Python to install packages into, so nothing else on your computer is affected. In the PowerShell window from Step 3, type:

TYPE THIS, THEN PRESS ENTER

```
python -m venv .venv
```

Nothing seems to happen for a few seconds, then the prompt comes back without any message. That means it worked. A new folder named **.venv** appears inside the Brücke folder. Leave it there and don't edit it.

5 Install Brücke's packages

Downloads the building blocks Brücke needs. 1 to 3 minutes.

Still in the same window, type this (carefully: it starts with a dot and has backslashes):

TYPE THIS, THEN PRESS ENTER

```
.venv\Scripts\python -m pip install -r requirements.txt
```

Lots of text scrolls past while packages download. Wait until the prompt returns. The last lines should look like:

WHAT YOU SHOULD SEE

```
Successfully installed anthropic-... fastapi-... uvicorn-... (and others)
```

Why the long ".venv\Scripts\python" at the start?

It tells Windows to use the Python **inside Brücke's toolbox**, the one that has the packages. If you type plain **python** or **uvicorn** later, Windows may pick a different Python that has none of them, and you get the error **No module named 'fastapi'**. So always type the commands exactly as written here.

6 Start Brücke and open it

The moment of truth.

TYPE THIS, THEN PRESS ENTER

```
.venv\Scripts\python -m uvicorn app.main:app
```

WHAT YOU SHOULD SEE

```
INFO:     Started server process [12345]
INFO:     Waiting for application startup.
INFO:     Application startup complete.
INFO:     Uvicorn running on http://127.0.0.1:8000 (Press CTRL+C to quit)
```

Brücke is now running. Open **Chrome** or **Edge** and type this into the address bar:

TYPE THIS INTO YOUR BROWSER'S ADDRESS BAR

```
http://localhost:8000
```

You should see Brücke's **Today** page. You're done with setup. Bookmark the page so it's one click next time.

> **Keep the PowerShell window open**
>
> That window *is* Brücke running. If you close it, the page stops working. You can minimise it, but don't close it while you're studying.

PART 2 · EVERY DAY

Starting and stopping Brücke

From now on you never repeat Steps 1, 2, 4 or 5. Each study session is just:

	To start studying	
1	Open the Brücke folder, click the address bar, type **powershell**, press Enter	(Step 3)
2	Type `.venv\Scripts\python -m uvicorn app.main:app` and press Enter	(Step 6)
3	Open **http://localhost:8000** in Chrome or Edge (or click your bookmark)	

To stop, click inside the PowerShell window and press **Ctrl+C**, or simply close the window. Your progress is saved automatically after every answer, so there's no "save" button to worry about.

> **Pressing the up-arrow key saves typing**
>
> In PowerShell, pressing ↑ brings back commands you typed before. After opening PowerShell in the Brücke folder, press ↑ until the start command appears, then press Enter.

Optional: a double-click starter

If you'd rather not type anything at all, make a small file that does steps 1–3 for you:

1. Open **Notepad** (Start → type **notepad** → Enter) and paste in these four lines exactly:

PASTE INTO NOTEPAD

```
@echo off
cd /d "%~dp0"
start "" http://localhost:8000
.venv\Scripts\python -m uvicorn app.main:app
```

2. Choose **File** → **Save as...** and go to your Brücke folder (the one with requirements.txt).
3. Change **Save as type** to **All files (*.*)**. This is important, otherwise Notepad adds ".txt".
4. Name it **Start Brucke.bat** and click **Save**.

Now just **double-click Start Brucke.bat**. A black window opens (that's Brücke running, so leave it open) and your browser opens Brücke. If the page says it can't connect, wait two seconds and press **F5** to refresh. Tip: right-click the file → **Show more options** → **Send to** → **Desktop (create shortcut)** to put it on your desktop.

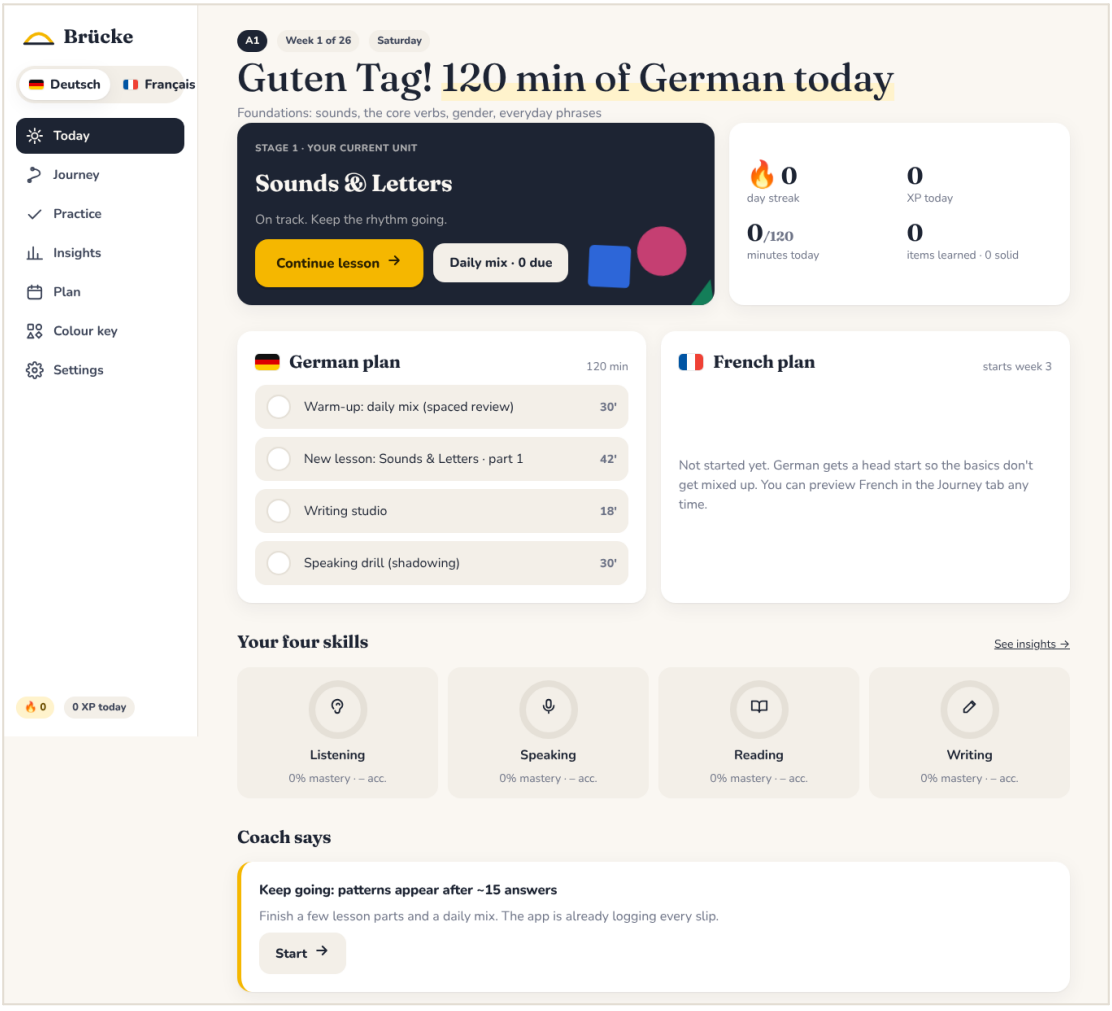
> **Windows might warn you the first time**
>
> If a blue "Windows protected your PC" box appears, click **More info** → **Run anyway**. It shows this for any new file it doesn't recognise, and you just wrote this one yourself.

A tour of the app

Brücke (German for *bridge*) uses English as the bridge to German and French. German starts in week 1 and French joins in week 3. The menu on the left takes you to every screen. Switch language with the **Deutsch / Français** buttons at the top of the menu.

Today: your daily plan

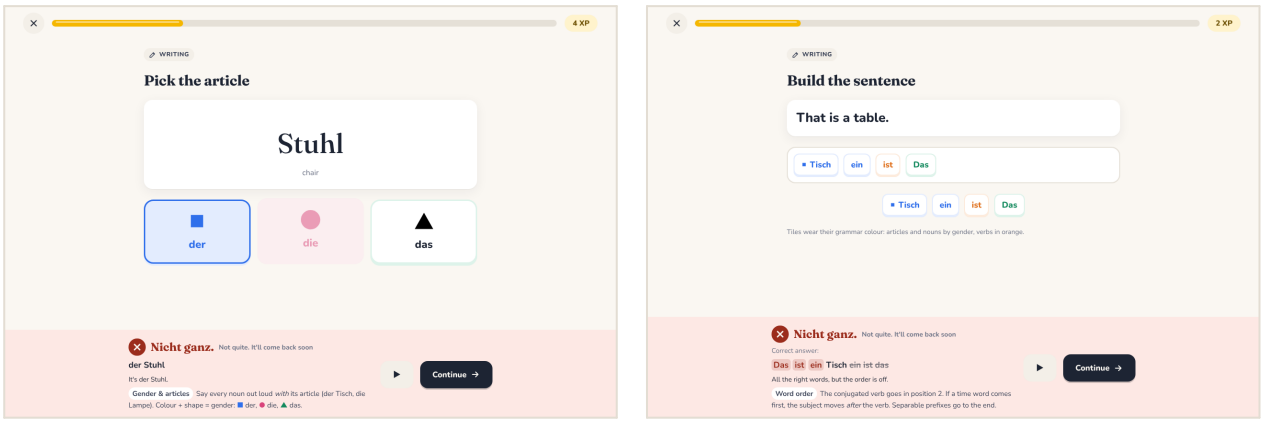
This is where every session begins. Press **Continue lesson** for new material, or **Daily mix** to review words that are due. The plan below lists today's blocks in order. Underneath you'll see how strong each of your four skills is (listening, speaking, reading, writing) and a tip from the coach.



The Today page on day one.

Answering exercises

Exercises mix all four skills: picking an article, building a sentence from tiles, typing what you hear, repeating a phrase out loud. After each answer a panel slides up. Green means correct. Red (*Nicht ganz*, "not quite") shows the right answer, explains **what kind of mistake** it was, and lets you replay the audio. Press **Continue** or **Enter** to move on. Anything you miss comes back again soon.



Left: pick the article. Right: build the sentence. Both show the feedback panel after a mistake.

The colour and shape code

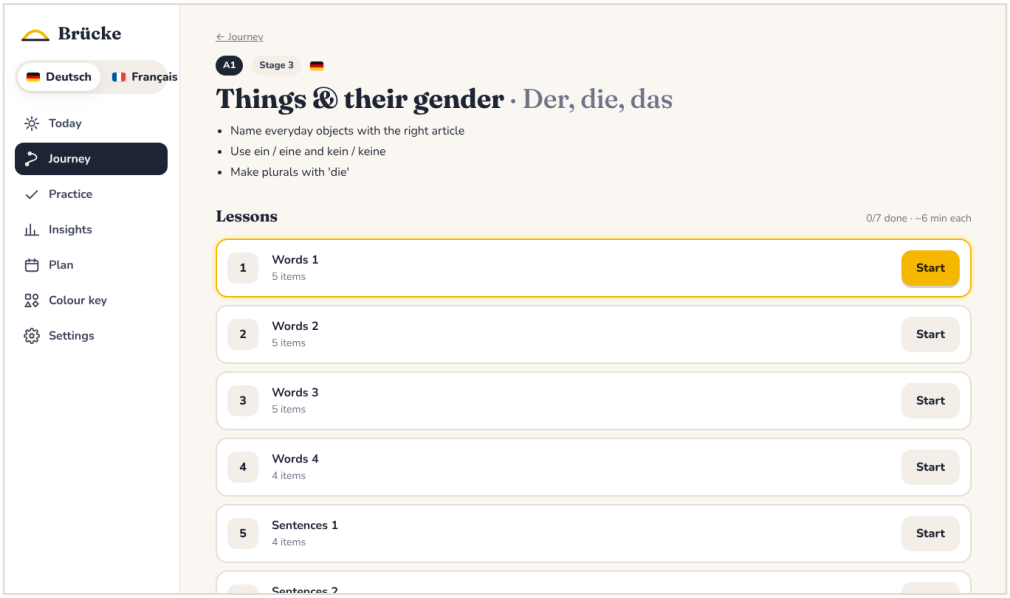
Brücke paints grammar the same way everywhere: in word lists, sentences, tiles and buttons. The shapes mean it still works if you're colour-blind. Learn these five and you'll see a word's gender at a glance:

	Means	German	French
■	**Blue square** · masculine	der Tisch	le livre
●	**Rose circle** · feminine	die Lampe	la table
▲	**Green triangle** · neuter	das Buch	(French has no neuter)
◆	**Violet diamond** · plural	die Bücher	les livres
→	**Orange arrow** · verbs	ist, haben	est, avoir

Open **Colour key** in the menu any time to see it again.

Journey: the whole course

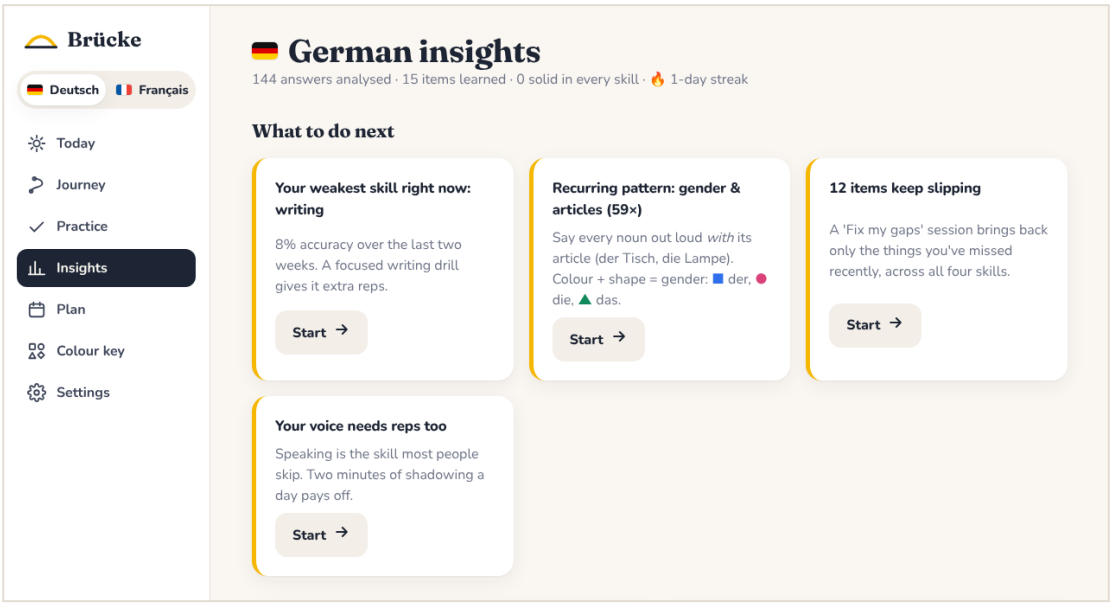
Journey shows all the stages. Open one to see its lessons (about 6 minutes each), short grammar explanations, the word list (click any word to hear it) and example sentences. Already know a topic? Use **"I know this"** to test out: score 85% or more and it's marked as done.



A unit in Journey: lessons, grammar ideas, then the words below.

Practice, Insights and Plan

- **Practice**: extra sessions on demand. It focuses on what's due for review, your weakest skill, and the mistakes you keep making.
- **Insights**: what you're good at and what keeps tripping you up, with a **Start** button next to each suggestion and a **Fix these** button for the words you keep missing. Patterns start appearing after about 15 answers.
- **Plan**: your 26-week timeline, the weekly rhythm (Sundays are for review) and checkpoint tests in weeks 4, 8, 13, 17, 22 and 26.



Insights turns your mistakes into suggestions.



Plan: German starts in week 1, French in week 3.

Settings

Change your **start date**, **minutes per day**, **which language comes first** and **when the second one starts**. Brücke adjusts difficulty automatically (levels 1–5). You can fix a level here if you prefer, or unlock the stretch stages towards B2 early.

Speaking and listening

- The first time an exercise needs your microphone, the browser asks for permission. Click **Allow**.
- You'll hear a phrase at normal and slow speed, then say it. Brücke scores you word by word and highlights the words it couldn't make out.
- No sound? Check your volume and that you're using Chrome or Edge, which have the most natural voices.

Keyboard shortcuts

Key	What it does
Enter	Check your answer / continue
1 – 4	Pick answer 1, 2, 3 or 4
Space	Replay the audio, or start the microphone
Esc	Leave the exercise
Ctrl + Enter	Submit your writing in the Writing studio

PART 4 · EXTRAS AND HELP

Optional: AI writing feedback

Everything in Brücke works without this. If you add an **Anthropic API key**, two extra features switch on: the **Writing studio** corrects your free writing with a score, a level estimate and explanations, and Brücke can **generate the full lessons** for the later stages (9–26), which otherwise exist only as outlines.

> **This costs money**
>
> An API key is billed by usage by Anthropic, the company behind Claude, separately from any Claude subscription. Treat the key like a password: never share it, and never send someone your Brücke folder while the key is in it.

1. Create an account at **console.anthropic.com**, add credit under **Billing**, then go to **API keys** → **Create key**. Copy the key. It starts with **sk-ant-**.
2. Open **Notepad** and type one line, pasting your own key after the equals sign (no spaces):

TYPE INTO NOTEPAD

```
ANTHROPIC_API_KEY=sk-ant-paste-your-key-here
```

3. **File** → **Save as...**, go to your Brücke folder, set **Save as type** to **All files (*.*)**, name it **.env** (a dot, then env, and nothing else) and save.
4. Stop Brücke (Ctrl+C in its window) and start it again (Step 6). It only reads the key when it starts.

> **Check the file name really is ".env"**
>
> In File Explorer, turn on **View** → **Show** → **File name extensions**. If you see **.env.txt**, rename it to **.env** and click Yes when Windows warns you about changing the extension.

Keep your progress safe

All your progress lives in a single file: **data\bruecke.db** inside the Brücke folder. It appears after your first session. To back it up, stop Brücke and then copy that file to a USB stick or cloud folder. To restore it, put the copy back in the same place.

Getting a newer version

1. Stop Brücke. Download and extract the new ZIP exactly as in Step 2, into a **new** folder.
2. Copy the **data** folder from your old Brücke folder into the new one, so your progress comes with you. If you set up AI feedback, copy **.env** across too.
3. Open PowerShell in the new folder and repeat **Steps 4, 5 and 6**. When everything works, you can delete the old folder.

When something goes wrong

Find the message you're seeing in the left column. Red text in PowerShell looks alarming, but it's usually one of these.

What you see	What it means	What to do
python : The term 'python' is not recognized, or typing python opens the Microsoft Store	Windows can't find Python yet.	Close PowerShell and open a new one. Try **py --version**. If neither works, redo Step 1 and tick "Add python.exe to PATH".
ModuleNotFoundError: No module named 'fastapi' (or 'uvicorn')	A Python *without* Brücke's packages was used.	Start Brücke with the full command: `.venv\Scripts\python -m uvicorn app.main:app`. Don't shorten it to just **uvicorn**. Still failing? Repeat Step 5.
Could not open requirements file, or **Could not import module "app.main"**	PowerShell isn't in the Brücke folder.	Close it and redo Step 3 from the folder that contains **requirements.txt** (watch for the folder-inside-a-folder trap).
The system cannot find the path specified when typing .venv\Scripts\python	The toolbox doesn't exist in this folder yet, or you're in the wrong folder.	Check you're in the right folder (Step 3), then do Steps 4 and 5.
[Errno 10048] or **address already in use**	Brücke is already running in another window.	Use the browser page that's already working, or close the other PowerShell/black window and start again.
Browser says **This site can't be reached** / **refused to connect**	Brücke isn't running.	Start it (Step 6) and keep its window open. Check the address is **http://localhost:8000**.
Microphone exercises don't hear you	The browser hasn't been given permission.	Click the icon at the left end of the address bar → **Microphone** → **Allow**, then refresh the page.
Writing studio says AI feedback isn't available	No API key was found.	Check the file is called exactly **.env** (not .env.txt), is in the Brücke folder, and that you restarted Brücke.
Lots of red text during Step 5	Usually a dropped internet connection.	Run the same command again. If it keeps failing, copy the last ten lines and send them to whoever shared Brücke with you.

Moved or renamed the Brücke folder?

The toolbox (.venv) remembers where it was created. If you move or rename the folder and something stops working, delete the **.venv** folder and repeat **Steps 4 and 5**. Your progress in **data** is not affected.

CHEAT SHEET

Everything on one page

Windows

When	Type this in PowerShell, inside the Brücke folder
Check Python is installed	`python --version`
Create the toolbox (once)	`python -m venv .venv`
Install packages (once)	`.venv\Scripts\python -m pip install -r requirements.txt`
Start Brücke (every time)	`.venv\Scripts\python -m uvicorn app.main:app`
Open it	**http://localhost:8000** in Chrome or Edge
Stop it	**Ctrl+C** in the PowerShell window, or close the window

Open PowerShell in a folder: click the File Explorer address bar, type **powershell**, press Enter.

On a Mac instead?

Use the **Mac edition** of this guide for full step-by-step instructions. In short: the steps are the same with three differences. Install Python from **python.org/downloads** (the macOS installer). Use the **Terminal** app instead of PowerShell: open it from Launchpad, type **cd** (with a space), drag the Brücke folder onto the window and press Enter. And on a Mac the paths use forward slashes:

When	Type this in Terminal, inside the Brücke folder
Check Python	`python3 --version`
Create the toolbox (once)	`python3 -m venv .venv`
Install packages (once)	`.venv/bin/python -m pip install -r requirements.txt`
Start Brücke	`.venv/bin/python -m uvicorn app.main:app`

Viel Erfolg! · Bonne chance !

Good luck. A little every day beats a lot once a week.